

You keep waiting for this to feel like less

8 findings · 14-step checklist · 1 myth · 8 sources · cheatgrid.com

No week count tells you whether you're on schedule. Most people misjudge how bad **the initial shock** feels, though their guess at the timeline usually lands close.

THE GOAL

You're watching what keeps this going, like contact and checking their page, instead of grading yourself against the calendar. Close whatever you're checking right now.

CHECKLIST

You catch yourself grading how bad you still feel against how many weeks it's been.

- ☐ **Put down or close** whatever you're checking right now, their profile, an old text thread, a photo.
- ☐ Name in one line what set this off just now (a song, a date, seeing their name), not just "I feel bad."
- ☐ Name one thing about yourself that's still true right now and has nothing to do with them (a habit, an opinion, a friendship).
- ☐ Sort what's pulling at you right now: wanting to check on them, wanting to message them, someone new, or just the low feeling.
- ☐ If it's the pull to check on them, log out or put your phone away for the next hour instead of opening their page.
- ☐ If it's the pull to message them, write what you want to say in a note instead of sending it, read it back tomorrow.
- ☐ If it's someone new pulling at you, let that stand on its own instead of proving to yourself you've grieved enough first.
- ☐ If it's just the low feeling, name it in one word out loud or in a note (sad, angry, tired), then move on.
- ☐ Go back to what you were doing before this hit, even something small, and finish that one thing first.
- ☐ Write down today's date and one line on how this compares to a few days ago, not to how many weeks it's been.
- ☐ If today felt worse than a few days ago, name what was different (an anniversary, a friend, a song) before deciding you've lost ground.
- ☐ Tell one person "today was a harder day" before the day ends.
- ☐ Set tomorrow's first task now, one thing you'll do regardless of how you feel when you wake up.
- ☐ If this has made it hard to work, sleep, or see people most days for weeks, **call a doctor or therapist** about it now.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Losing track of who you are without them is **real**, not proof you never had a life of your own.
- 2 Being the person who got left goes with a harder time right when it happens, whether or not you saw it coming.
- 3 Most people misjudge how bad **the initial shock** will feel. Their timeline guess is usually close to right.

What's making this feel like your fault

KNOW

Losing track of who you are without them is **real**, not proof you never had a life of your own.

People going through a breakup answered questions about themselves less clearly than before, and that drop went with how distressed they felt. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Being the person who got left goes with a harder time right when it happens, whether or not you saw it coming.

Those who'd recently broken up and were asked about it ranked being left among the things most tied to their distress. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Feeling ready for someone new this soon isn't a warning sign.

People who started dating again sooner than others reported more psychological and relational health, not less. [Source 3](#)

How the pain is actually moving

KNOW

Most people misjudge how bad **the initial shock** will feel. Their timeline guess is usually close to right.

Before any breakup happened, people predicted their own future distress, then had it compared with how they felt weeks later. [Source 4](#)

WATCH

A rough day out of nowhere doesn't erase the progress you've made.

Sadness and anger rise and fall on their own schedule, while loving feelings toward them fade in a steadier line. [Source 5](#)

KNOW

Time alone won't do it. What moves your sadness is whether you've accepted the relationship is over.

Accepting that the relationship was over, more than time itself, was what linked a secure attachment style to faster sadness recovery. [Source 6](#)

What's stretching it out longer than it needs to

DON'T

Staying in regular contact with them, a call or seeing them in person, doesn't keep your recovery steady this early. Contact like that goes with more love and more sadness on those days, not less.

On days people had phone or in-person contact with an ex, they reported more love and sadness that day too. [Source 5](#)

DON'T

Checking their profile still counts as contact, even if it feels harmless. Active searching goes with a worse day right then, and tends to carry into tomorrow too.

People who journaled nightly reported worse mood on days they'd actively searched, and still felt it into the next day. [Source 7](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Getting over a breakup takes about half as long as the relationship lasted, so if you're not there by that point, you're behind.

ACTUALLY

There's no research behind that formula. It's a number that gets repeated so often it starts to sound measured, and **treating it as a deadline** just adds pressure on top of an already hard stretch. [Source 8](#)

Sources

1. https://faculty.wcas.northwestern.edu/eli-finkel/documents/2010_SlotterGardnerFinkel_PSPB.pdf
2. <https://pure.psu.edu/en/publications/factors-associated-with-distress-following-the-breakup-of-a-close/>
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5. <https://experts.arizona.edu/en/publications/the-emotional-sequelae-of-nonmarital-relationship-dissolution-ana/>

6. <https://experts.arizona.edu/en/publications/predicting-the-onset-of-emotional-recovery-following-nonmarital-r/>
7. <https://www.psypost.org/social-media-surveillance-of-ex-partners-linked-to-worse-breakup-recovery/>
8. <https://www.match.com/p/dating-advice/break-up/how-long-does-it-take-to-get-over-a-breakup/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Breaking up at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)